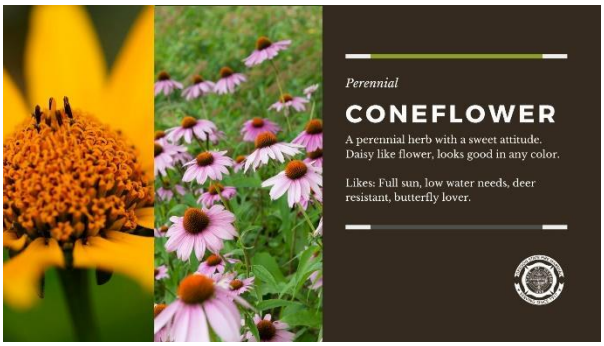
From the Desk of Chief Schick, Western Lane Fire & EMS Authority ***September 2024***

Fire Resistant Plants for Home Landscapes

Fire-safe landscaping uses fire-resistant plants that do not readily ignite from a flame or other ignition sources. Landscaping this way needn't be expensive and can increase your property value while conserving water. Good fire-resistant ground covers include sedum, creeping phlox, Dianthus, and Kinnikinnick. Good perennial choices include Yarrow, Columbine, Delphinium and Trumpet Vine. Rhododendrons, Vine maple and Serviceberry work well in the shrub category. As for trees, look for Amur maple, Birch, Flowering dogwood, Hawthorn, American sweetgum or Quaking aspen. As Oregon's urban areas continue to expand, so, too, do the risks of wildfires that jump from forest-to-rooftop-to community. Take some time this fall to inspect your home and property, reduce fuels around your home and include fire-resistant plants in the landscape.

Selecting fire-resistant plants

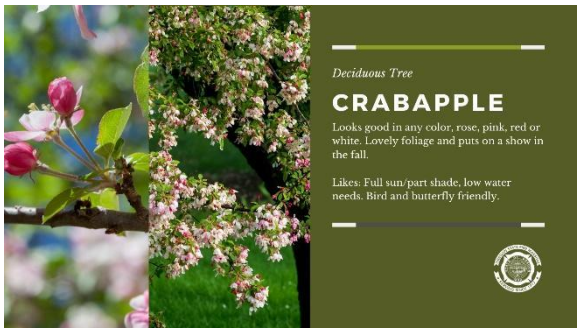
Landscape environments vary throughout the Pacific Northwest. Always check with your local Extension office or a nursery when selecting fire-resistant plant material. Avoid invasive plants and ensure your choices are suitable for your environment. You may choose from an array of attractive, fire resistant trees and other plants. Most people choose plants based on flower color, light requirements (sun or shade), fragrance or overall appearance. These are all valid reasons for selecting plants.



But your first priority in a fire-wise landscape should be to select the fire-resistant plants best adapted to your region. Group plants with similar adaptability, water, soil and sunlight requirements. Use drought-tolerant plants in drier locations. When choosing non-native plants, make sure they are non-invasive. Invasive plants can displace native plants, causing both environmental and economic damage. The mature size of plants is an often-overlooked factor to consider. This is especially important when planting trees or shrubs near homes. Ensure adequate spacing so that fire cannot spread into the canopy or touch roof lines as the plants mature. Allow enough space for a

plant to fill in without needing to severely prune it or move it as it matures. In the 5- to 30-foot zone, choose low-growing (12 inches or less) perennials or groundcovers over taller ones. Many other factors contribute to whether a plant will survive and become more fire-prone. These include soil type, rainfall, heat tolerance, and exposure to wind and sun. Consider the microclimates that exist in your community and your own backyard.

Placing, spacing, mulching and maintenance



While plant selection is important, so are design and plant spacing. Avoid placing any plant material within 5 feet of the home, known as the immediate zone in the HIZ. The intermediate zone (5–30 feet out from the home) can include fire-resistant plants that are well-maintained and adequately spaced. Allow 10 feet or more between group plantings. Increase these distances if your home is on or near slopes. Allow ample space between plantings both vertically and horizontally. Avoid planting in rows, as this can create a continuous path of fuel for fire to spread. Reduce ladder fuels (Figure 5) by removing tall grass, shrubs and small trees beneath larger trees. Keep a minimum of 15 feet between tree branches and your home. To maintain your fire-wise landscape, follow best practices on pruning, watering, mowing heights and plant placement.

Designing for small spaces in urban lots

In more urban environments, houses are closer together with smaller lot sizes. Firewise landscape practices still apply to plant selection, spacing and fuel reduction. But the key to protecting urban homes on smaller lots is cooperation within neighborhoods. Take an organized approach to communicating expectations for a fire-wise community. For example, fuel reduction — such as removing pine needles or plant debris from gutters and roofs — should be a goal for all homeowners.

Using decorative mulch and hardscapes in your landscape

Mulch can help conserve moisture, minimize erosion and suppress weeds. However, it's important to use the right type of mulch and in the right locations. Bark mulch, while a popular choice in home landscapes, IS NOT recommended within 5 feet of a home. Bark mulch or chips can easily ignite, especially when dry.

Also avoid recycled rubber mulch materials, which are highly flammable. Instead, consider using nonflammable decorative rock or gravel, especially in areas adjacent to your home Hardscaping is the use of pavers, boulders, statues, benches — anything that is not a living plant but adds design features or utility to your outdoor living space. Hardscape features that are noncombustible can add beauty and create a defensible space around the home.

Annuals and bulbs

Annuals and spring-blooming bulbs can be part of a fire-resistant landscape if well-watered and maintained. This publication does not list individual annuals due to the large number of choices available to homeowners.

Turf

You can include a well-maintained lawn in a fire-resistant landscape. Keep grass mowed to an appropriate height for your grass type. Mow to 3–4 inches. Your lawn should be well-irrigated, thriving and free of dead patches or unkept weedy areas. Some common cool-season grasses include Kentucky bluegrass, turf-type tall fescue, perennial ryegrass, fine fescue and bentgrass. Some types are more drought tolerant than others. For more information on lawn care and maintenance, see the OSU Extension website, https://extension. oregonstate.edu/gardening/lawn.

Not on the list: ornamental grasses, conifers and vines

Ornamental grasses, conifers and vines add design and beauty to a landscape. Unfortunately, they have characteristics not suited for a fire-wise design. Most ornamental grasses grow too tall, and conifers contain flammable oils. Continuous stands of taller grasses can contribute to fire spread. Tall grasses planted beneath trees can spread fire to the branches. Vines can act as a ladder fuel. If you plant vines, place them in isolated areas away from the home. Avoid planting vines under other vegetation. If you choose to include grasses or conifers, place them away from the home in isolated areas. Avoid planting beneath trees. Frequent maintenance of conifers and ornamental grasses is critical to reducing fire risk. Trim dry, dead stalks and prune lower branches 6 to 10 feet from the ground to limit ladder fuels. When pruning branches, avoid removing more than 30% of the original canopy to prevent excessive stress to the tree. Leaving some lower branches for wildlife is acceptable farther away from the home (30- to 100-foot zone) as long as the tree is spaced away from other vegetation. Don't plant conifers next to a home. If you have established conifers near your home that you cannot bear to remove, consider some mitigating actions. Prune overhanging branches and limbs. Create a minimum of 10 feet of clearance from the roof. Space other plants and shrubs farther away from conifers. Because conifers drop needles on roofs and gutters, annual cleaning is a must.

For additional information go to https://extension.oregonstate.edu/catalog/pub/pnw-590-fire-resistant-plants-home-landscapes .

For local information, go to https://www.wlfea.org/.